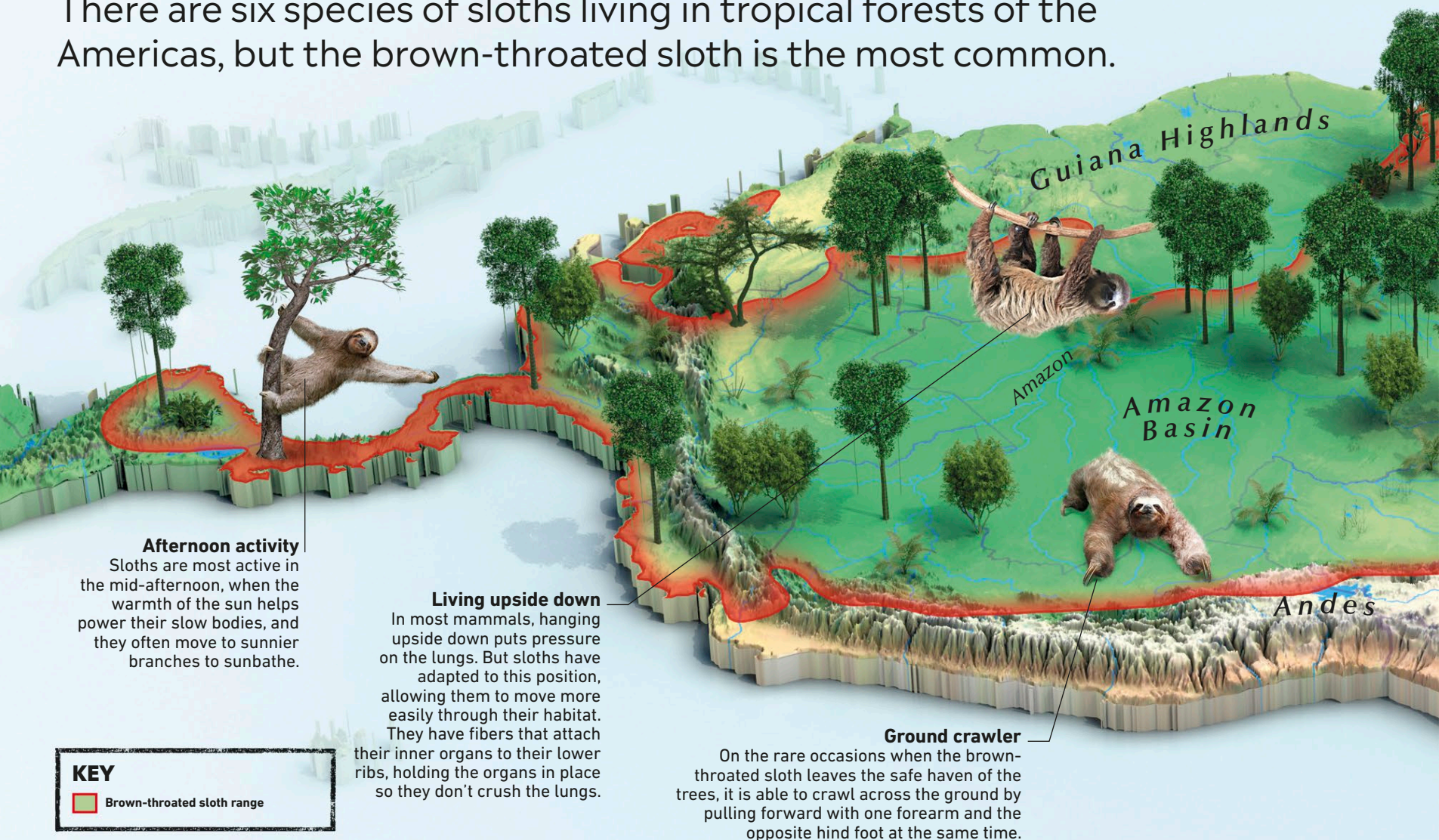


Brown-throated sloth

Few animals are so tied to life in trees as the sloth. These plant-eaters climb the branches with slow, deliberate movements and have long arms and claws that act as grappling hooks. There are six species of sloths living in tropical forests of the Americas, but the brown-throated sloth is the most common.



Afternoon activity

Sloths are most active in the mid-afternoon, when the warmth of the sun helps power their slow bodies, and they often move to sunnier branches to sunbathe.

Living upside down

In most mammals, hanging upside down puts pressure on the lungs. But sloths have adapted to this position, allowing them to move more easily through their habitat. They have fibers that attach their inner organs to their lower ribs, holding the organs in place so they don't crush the lungs.

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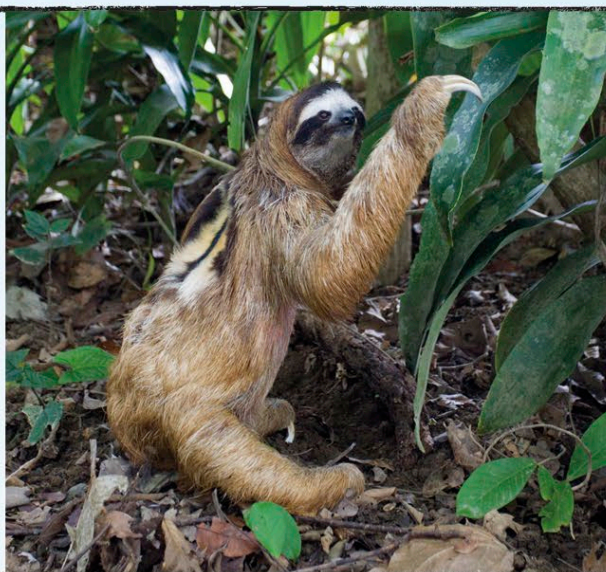
 Brown-throated sloth range

Ground crawler

On the rare occasions when the brown-throated sloth leaves the safe haven of the trees, it is able to crawl across the ground by pulling forward with one forearm and the opposite hind foot at the same time.

Trips to the toilet

The brown-throated sloth descends from the trees for just one reason: to poo. Once a week, it makes its way down to the forest floor, digs a small depression with its short tail, and defecates. It then covers the dung with leaf litter and climbs back up. If forced to do so, a sloth can crawl along the ground using the soles of its front and back feet, but will soon make for the nearest tree to return to the safety of the canopy.



Living together

Algae that grow on the fur of the brown-throated sloth tinge its fur green, helping disguise it among the leaves. The algae are fertilized by the droppings of a species of moth that lives only in the sloth's fur. When the sloth descends to the ground to poo, the moths briefly leave the sloth's fur to lay their eggs, and their larvae feed on the dung.

